

A MIRACLE IN A CEMETERY

* Blue denotes PPT Slide

* Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Matthew 28:1-6 (NKJV) *“Now after the Sabbath, as the first day of the week began to dawn, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to see the tomb. ²And behold, there was a great earthquake; for an angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat on it. ³His countenance was like lightning, and his clothing as white as snow. ⁴And the guards shook for fear of him, and became like dead men. ⁵But the angel answered and said to the women, “Do not be afraid, for I know that you seek Jesus who was crucified. ⁶“He is not here; for He is risen, as He said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay.”*

INTRO: The scene from our text is in a cemetery, at sunrise, on the first Easter morning. A cemetery is a not a place where you find a lot of hope, quite the contrary is true:

- A cemetery is a burial ground for the dead...
- A cemetery is a place where dreams are laid to rest...
- A cemetery is a place where hope dims, flickers and dies...
- A cemetery is a place for reflecting on what could have been...
- A cemetery is a place for beautiful flowers to wither and die...
- A cemetery is a place where grief deadens the tune of victorious songs...
- A cemetery is a place where money loses its power to buy its way out...
- A cemetery is a place where we are forced to accept the finality of fate...

In this particular cemetery there were no doubt old tombs well marked by the weathering streaks, of Father Time. Others were recently occupied.

One plot housed the remains of an unorthodox religious leader who had been executed publicly and shamefully only hours before. Mourners had carried his limp, bruised and bleeding body from Golgotha to this resting place of the dead.

The brownish plank that hung above his head on the cross leaned against the cold rock that sealed his tomb. Engraved into the plank were these words: ***“Jesus, King of the Jews”!***

Two women could be seen making their way into the cemetery through the gray dawn shadows of a spring day. The women who were coming to this cemetery were obviously emotionally distraught. With painstaking effort, they made their way to the tomb of the victim of the recent crucifixion. Tenderly and gently, as only a mother can, one of these ladies had come to give her son a decent and proper burial. A mother and her trusted friend were paying their last respects to a son whose life held such promise. But now, at only thirty-three and one half years of age, the beloved son of a mother who had given so much would be nothing but a faint memory, and a short inscription on a tomb marker!

There is no pain that can equal the pain of a mother who has lost her child. This cemetery on the outskirts of Jerusalem appeared to be the most unlikely place on the earth to experience a miracle!

Usually the most unlikely place is the very place God reserves to perform His best miracles:

- Wedding in Cana of Galilee...
- The resurrection of Lazarus...
- Cleansing of the ten lepers...
- Miracle of a blind man receiving his sight by washing in the pool of Siloam...

Matthew draws our attention to another group of people in the cemetery, and they were a group of soldiers, who were frightened out of their minds. (Guy who fell into an open grave late one night not knowing a drunk had fallen in there earlier in the evening...) Remember, these guys were calloused, emotionally unattached monsters, but they were frozen by fear when a man from outer space showed up with the keys to a sepulcher housing a political and religious martyr!

I want you to get the full picture; this is a dreary, gloomy, dark cemetery. The characters in the story are two emotionally distraught women, and two or three soldiers that were scared stiff. This cast of

unlikely characters constituted the audience for this miracle in a cemetery!

It shouldn't surprise me, but it does: **God performs some of his most incredible activities in some of the most inconspicuous places!** (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

- God chose the back side of a desert to defy the law of conflagration by allowing a bush to burn but not be consumed...
- God chose a group of shepherds and a Judean hillside to display heavens choir of angels...
- God chose a stable in Bethlehem to be the birthplace of His only Son...
- God chose a hillside in Israel to contradict the law of diminishing returns by feeding 5,000 men with a little boy's lunch...

Based on what we already know, it should not come as a great surprise to us that God stages the miracle of all miracles in a cemetery! This miracle was not performed in space, a science lab, a palace, or before an important crowd! This miracle was performed in a cemetery!

God chose this cemetery, which represents man's extremity, to display the awesome power of his Divinity!

I. THE MIRACLE IN THE CEMETERY OCCURRED DESPITE ATTITUDES...

If the attitudes in this cemetery had been a contributing factor to the miracle, Jesus would still be slumbering in the tomb. Please do not misunderstand what I am saying here, I know there are times when God acts in direct proportion to the Faith we have exercised. I realize there are times when God limits what he does, because we have not been able to raise the threshold of our Faith.

On the other hand, however, there are some things that God does as a total independent act of his Sovereignty. In instances such as that, he acts alone and independent of our approval or disapproval, our faith or doubt, and also independent of our attitudes, good or bad! An independent act of God's sovereignty is exactly what occurs in this story. **The Resurrection was a sovereign act of a sovereign God!**
(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

To the best of my knowledge, no one was expecting Jesus to walk out of that grave but God! He had told his disciples over and over that He would die, and on the third day rise again, but they did not comprehend the full thrust of what He was saying! They had their minds on building an earthly kingdom.

When this miracle occurred, the trust level of everyone involved was at zero! The ordeal of the past week was enough to cripple the trust level of the strongest believer. Trust was depleted because:

- The church treasurer had been caught up in a scandal and committed suicide...
- The justice system had gone insane, innocent people were executed, and guilty people were being pardoned...
- The public had become a lynch mob, striking out at anything that did not fit into their way of thinking...
- The Rose of Sharon had been crushed under the boot of oppression...

There is little wonder that good news was met with skepticism, the Bible said that “*Some doubted*” that Jesus had been raised from the dead!

More than twenty centuries have come and gone, but distrust lives on. In this culture:

- Families are being pulled apart by a lack of trust...
- Business are crashing and burning because of a lack of trust...
- Investments have disappeared because of a lack of trust...
- The government is bankrupt because it cannot be trusted...

The two ladies coming to the cemetery before dawn, no doubt had an attitude of worry and their trust was at an all time low! Worry was a factor that the cross had not cured. They probably dreaded the ordeal of trying to move the huge rock blocking their entrance into the tomb. They worried about a problem they would never have to face! The stone had been moved when they arrived at the tomb! That worry was in vain, as is most worry!

The ladies in this cemetery were overcome by fear of the angels, when in fact there was nothing at all to fear. The angels were their friends! Angels are here

today and they are our friends! (If we could just get our spiritual eyes opened!!!)

These ladies probably wondered if someone had stolen the Lord's body. They fretted over a situation they did not understand. They conjured up a picture in their mind that did not exist. No one had stolen the body of Jesus. He no longer needed the tomb, and moved out!

It is not difficult to see the attitude of discouragement in the eyes of the disciples; they were beat; they had no fight left in them; they went into hiding; they had slept through Prayer Meeting the night before Jesus was crucified and was nowhere to be found at his crucifixion. The morale among the disciples was non-existent!

Pilate and the Pharisees had an attitude of disdain. They fought the miracles of God, as a matter of fact; they did everything they could do to prevent the promises of God from coming to pass.

The attitudes in the cemetery were:

- Lack of trust...
- Discouragement...

- Worry...
- Agnosticism

No attitude can abort the sovereign miracles of a sovereign God!

II. THE MIRACLE IN THE CEMETERY WAS NOT LIMITED BY CIRCUMSTANCES...

Because of the miracles of Jesus, an outright effort was launched to circumvent the plan of God:

- Roman soldiers had escorted the body of Jesus to a borrowed tomb...
- Roman soldiers sealed the tomb of Jesus...
- Roman soldiers were posted at the tomb day and night...
- The Roman government was committed to overseeing this whole ordeal...

It was like a gnat attempting to stall a freight train! It was like a dirt dauber trying to seal the gaping mouth of a belching volcano! It was like a moron trying to drain the ocean with a teacup! Their best efforts were futile, they could not stop the plan of God, and no one else will be able to do so either! (In our day we are hearing warnings about global warming – The Bible say's during the Great Tribulation that ***"The***

sun will scorch men with heat!” This planet was designed with a shelf life!)

If the Resurrection of Jesus from the dead were in any way dependent on Circumstances, He would still be in the cemetery!

There is another incident that occurred in this cemetery that must not be overlooked, Matthew says *“Behold, there was a great earthquake.”* This incident represents a natural phenomenon. An earthquake is normally referred to as an *“Act of God”* by the modern liberal media. In other words, an earthquake is something beyond our control. The capacity of an earthquake for destruction is almost without limits. An earthquake:

- Bends steel...
- Busts boulders...
- Buries buildings...
- Breaks structures into splinters...
- Bounces Mountains around like a rubber ball...
- Breaks holes in the surface of the earth like tearing a piece of paper...

This natural phenomenon is a circumstance of major proportion.

The body of Jesus was in a tomb, which was a cave of sorts that was carved out of layers of rock and dirt. Any movement of the earth could be totally disastrous. Slabs of rock could be shaken from the roof and mutilate the corpse.

Two such quakes had been observed in the previous seventy-two hours, one when Jesus died, the earth shook like a bowl of jello to express its horror, and now it shakes **again to celebrate the resurrection of the Rock of Ages!**

Natural circumstances have not, do not, and will not limit God! Nature has and always will be subject to the will of its Creator: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Stars staged a parade and traversed the heavens when Christ was born...
- Water blushed into wine at His command...
- Winds obeyed His voice without resistance...
- The sun hid its face and refused to illumine the scene of His crucifixion...
- Rocks wrenched in agony when He died...

- A boulder rolled away from His empty shroud like a marble, when He bid death a final farewell...

Just minutes before the resurrection the circumstances could not have been worse! Jesus was not sick or comatose; He was dead! Not only was He dead, He had been buried! Not only was He dead and buried, he had been in that grave three days. God chose the very worst circumstances to let us know that nothing which happens to us is too difficult for Him to handle!

God takes the darkest night of despair and turns it into a miracle for us! Psalms 30:5 (NKJV)
“For His anger is but for a moment, His favor is for life; Weeping may endure for a night, But joy comes in the morning.”

III. THE MIRACLE IN THE CEMETERY WAS NOT LIMITED TO HUMAN RESOURCES...

Matthew 28:2-4 (NKJV) *“Behold, there was a great earthquake; for an angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat on it.”*³ *His countenance was like lightning, and his clothing as white as snow.*

⁴And the guards shook for fear of him, and became like dead men.” Let me tell you, there was more than two emotionally distraught women and a couple of frightened soldiers present that day, the Scripture say’s *“The angel of the Lord came down!”* Listen to this:

- Angels celebrated His advent...
- Angels sympathized with Him in His agony...
- Angels comforted bereaved believers at His ascension...
- Angels are schedule to share the triumph with Him in the apocalypse that is soon to come...

The miracle in this cemetery called for something beyond human resources, so it should be no wonder that angels broadcast the news, when His abolition was aborted.

Angels are from outside our galaxy. They exist for the purpose of doing the will of God. When human frailty falters, angels carry out the plan of God! Daniel came to a moment of time when human resources were of no value. Lions don’t mediate, they maul! God sent His angels to lock the mouths of the lions and they did him no harm! In the truest sense

of the word, Daniel's only hope was in God and God delivered on His promise!

Napoleon once said, *"Extraordinary problems call for extraordinary remedies."*

The word *Extraordinary* means, *"To go far beyond the ordinary, to be unusual or remarkable."*

(LEAVE THIS SLIDE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

The Resurrection of Jesus meets that criterion. It proceeded beyond the ordinary! This was an extraordinary remedy, prescribed by an extraordinary God, who thinks nothing of going beyond finite limitations! At Gods direction:

- A fish became a submarine to rush an erratic preacher to his next preaching assignment...
- The orbital paths of the planets were temporarily suspended to bring a prophecy to pass...
- A donkey was used to speak to a disobedient prophet...
- A barnyard rooster answered the call of God to serve as a personal envoy for Jesus Christ, in order to speak to Peter, Jesus' most unpredictable disciple...

Because of the miracle in a cemetery the tomb Jesus occupied is now empty, no longer needed, and can be returned to its owner! Jesus did not buy a tomb; He just rented one! He was only going to use it for three day's! The Lord of Glory moved out via the Resurrection!

CONCLUSION:

The resurrection is the greatest miracle in the history of the world, and tells me that **there's nothing that God can't do!** (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME UNTIL ALL ARE ON THE SCREEN, THEN LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)

- God has never seen a problem He could not solve...
- God has never seen a hurt He could not heal...
- God has never seen a battle He could not win...
- God has never seen a question He could not answer...
- God has never seen an obligation He could not meet...
- God has never seen a failure He could not fix...
- God has never seen a loss He could not restore...

The reason that God can do all of this for us is because on that first Easter morning there was a miracle in a cemetery and now the tomb is empty! He's alive! Because He lives, you and I can live as well!